

Teaching Philosophy

My teaching experience at The University of Iowa has included working with graduate and undergraduate students as a teaching assistant, tutor, and lecturer. Each experience and teaching role has presented its own challenges and rewards, and provided me with a better understanding of the learning and teaching process at both the introductory and advanced level. I have high standards for both myself and my students, and this commitment to excellence is evidenced by my reception of the Economics Department's Outstanding Teaching Assistant Award.

Teaching is an integral part of the process of understanding any topic, and in my view is inexorably linked to research. In both cases, the end goal is similar: to persuade others of the merit of new ideas and provide the tools for their application. While in research, these ideas may be novel to the field and push the state of our collective understanding, in both cases the audience is previously uninitiated and must first be persuaded of the merit and importance of the material at hand. To me, this highlights a primary requirement of successful teaching, which is the need to engage the student and convince them of the usefulness of economics and the relevance of its methods in understanding their environment.

The value of motivation was made especially clear to me through lecturing in my own course in intermediate macroeconomics. My students were most engaged and motivated when they felt connected to topics through events and scenarios that directly affected and interested them. Showing students that they already face the tradeoffs in their models and placing them in the context of the decision maker helps them to realize the intuitiveness and usefulness of economic theories. The second aspect of motivation is to convince them of the significance of the material and how it applies to the world beyond their immediate scope and the topics in the classroom. Luckily, economics seeks the answer to some of the most important questions facing society and applies to almost every aspect of modern life. This has also been a benefit to my own research in helping me to focus on the bigger ideas and questions that my work seeks to address, and find ways to motivate their importance to a broader audience.

The challenge in teaching is often in knowing the right balance between focusing on providing the broad understanding and application of topics and imparting the technical proficiency and toolset to further analyze them. Understanding the needs and abilities of students is critical to know this balance. My experience tutoring individual students helped me to see the necessity as well as the challenges in addressing these two goals. The interaction of students with the teacher through assignments and in person is critical in knowing when one aspect is lacking, and I try to provide an accessible environment for questions and student input inside and outside of the classroom. Technology facilitates timely and frequent conversation with students through course discussions and forums, which I use to supplement lectures with novel topics or current events and to provide and receive feedback.

My experience working with other graduate students in the Analysis and Macro sequences gave me an appreciation for the role of teaching in facilitating my own learning and development. Guiding other students through the Ph.D. core was especially exciting, and through their discussions and

questions, helped me to arrive at a better understanding of both the tools of economics and its intuition. Through my experiences, I feel that I have improved both as a teacher and as an economist, and look forward to continuing to converse and engage with both my students and colleagues.